

Unethical Issues in the Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) Among Undergraduates in Public Universities of Cross River State, Nigeria

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Abstract

The objective of the study is to investigate unethical issues in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates in public Universities in Cross River State. The study was conducted in University of Calabar and University of Cross River State. Survey research design was adopted of the study. The population of this study comprised all final year students in the two public Universities in Cross River State. The population of final year students in University of Calabar and University of Cross River State comprised of 7,020 undergraduate students as recorded by Academic Planning Unit & Management Information System, 2023/2024 of the respective Universities. Stratified random sampling was adopted for the study. A total sample of 409 students which constitute 10% of the population of students in the study area sampling from population of 4081 students from fifty three (53) departments of University of Calabar and University of Cross River State. A questionnaire titled Unethical issues in the Use of Artificial intelligence Questionnaire (UIUAIQ) was developed by the researchers. This was subjected to face and content validity by three experts in measurement and evaluation in Faculty of Education University of Calabar. A trial tested on fifty (50) students from College of Health Technology Calabar to establish the reliability of the instrument. Cronbach Alpha coefficient was used to determine the reliability estimate of the instrument $\alpha = .70-.72$. The instrument was administered to the respondents and retrieved with Zero attrition rate. This process was facilitated by the researcher and two trained research assistants. The data collected was analyzed through descriptive statistics of mean and standard deviation. The findings of this study reveal a significant prevalence of unethical issues in the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) among undergraduates in public universities in Cross River State. Furthermore, the study also indicates a high level of over-reliance on AI technologies among undergraduates, leading to reduced engagement in academic tasks and a decline in deep learning experiences. Based on the findings, it was recommended among others that Higher institutions should incorporate AI ethics education into their curriculum to sensitize students about the ethical implications of AI misuse.

Key Words: *Unethical issues, use of Artificial intelligence, plagiarism and Misuse, over-reliance on AI*

Introduction

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has become an integral component of modern university education, aiming to enhance learning experiences, streamline administrative processes, and prepare students for a technologically advanced workforce. The primary goal of AI in university education is to improve efficiency, foster creativity, and provide adaptive learning experiences tailored to individual student needs (Russell & Norvig, 2021). However, the rise of AI usage among undergraduates has raised concerns about ethical implications, particularly regarding academic integrity and responsible digital practices. Artificial Intelligence refers to the capability of machines to mimic cognitive functions typically associated with human intelligence, such as learning, reasoning, and problem-solving. According to Russell and Norvig (2021), AI encompasses systems that perceive their environment and take actions to maximize their chances of achieving specific goals. High-profile applications of AI include advanced web search engines, recommendation systems, virtual assistants, autonomous vehicles, generative tools like ChatGPT, and superhuman play in strategy games. However, the rise of AI usage among undergraduates has raised concerns about ethical implications, particularly regarding academic integrity and responsible digital practices.

Ethical AI use in university education requires students to engage responsibly with AI tools to enhance learning without compromising academic integrity. Undergraduates are expected to use AI-generated content as a supplementary resource rather than as a direct replacement for independent thinking and critical analysis (Floridi & Cows, 2019). Ethical guidelines emphasize transparency, proper citation of AI-assisted work, and adherence to institutional policies regarding academic honesty. Additionally, students are encouraged to develop digital literacy skills that enable them to evaluate AI-generated information critically and avoid over-reliance on automated solutions.

Despite the benefits of AI in education, there is growing concern about its unethical use among undergraduates. The misuse of AI-powered tools for generating essays, solving assignments, and completing research papers without proper attribution has become widespread. Studies indicate that AI-driven plagiarism detection software has identified an increase in AI-assisted academic dishonesty, leading to concerns about the authenticity of student work (Cotton et al., 2023). Plagiarism is the act of using another person's work without proper attribution, and AI has exacerbated this issue by enabling students to generate essays, reports, and research papers without original thought. AI-powered tools like ChatGPT, paraphrasing software, and automated essay generators allow students to produce content with minimal effort, often without understanding the subject matter. According to Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway (2023), the rise of AI-assisted plagiarism poses a significant threat to academic integrity, as students submit AI-generated content as their own work without proper citations. Universities have implemented plagiarism detection software, but AI tools are evolving to evade detection, making it challenging to uphold academic honesty.

Another major unethical issue is students' over-reliance on AI for academic tasks, which diminishes their critical thinking and problem-solving abilities. Rather than engaging in independent learning and research, students increasingly depend on AI to answer questions, generate solutions, and complete assignments. Selwyn (2020) argues that this dependence on AI leads to intellectual laziness, reducing students' ability to analyze and synthesize information. AI

tools provide instant answers, but they do not foster deep understanding, which is crucial for academic growth. As a result, students may perform well in assessments but lack the necessary skills to apply their knowledge in real-world situations. Many students depend excessively on AI tools for problem-solving and critical thinking tasks, leading to a decline in independent cognitive skills. This over-reliance can create an illusion of competence, where students appear to perform well but lack deep understanding (Selwyn, 2020).

The unethical use of AI has far-reaching consequences on students and the education system. Firstly, it diminishes students' ability to think critically and solve problems independently, leading to graduates who are ill-equipped for the workforce (O'Neil, 2016). Secondly, it fosters a culture of dishonesty, where students prioritize convenience over ethical learning. Thirdly, academic institutions risk losing credibility when AI-driven plagiarism becomes widespread, leading to employers and society questioning the value of university degrees (Floridi & Cowls, 2019). Lastly, the over-reliance on AI may lead to a decline in research quality, as students depend on AI-generated information rather than engaging in rigorous academic inquiry.

This situation is unacceptable because education is supposed to be an instrument for national development and personal growth. According to Nigeria's National Policy on Education (NPE), one of the key objectives of education is to “develop the individual into a sound and effective citizen” and to “train the mind in the understanding of the world” (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 2013). However, the misuse of AI contradicts these goals by promoting intellectual dishonesty and reducing students' ability to think independently. If students graduate without acquiring the necessary skills, they cannot contribute meaningfully to national development, thereby defeating the purpose of higher education.

Several measures have been taken to address the unethical use of AI in education, including the introduction of plagiarism detection software such as Turnitin and Grammarly, academic integrity policies, and digital literacy programs (Cotton et al., 2023). Universities have also conducted awareness campaigns on ethical AI use and imposed penalties for AI-assisted plagiarism. However, these efforts have yielded limited results, as AI tools continue to evolve, making it easier for students to bypass detection mechanisms. While AI offers numerous educational benefits, the unethical use of these technologies among undergraduates in public universities in Cross River State raises critical concerns that necessitate an in-depth investigation.

Objectives

The objective of the study is to investigate unethical issues in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates in public Universities in Cross River State. Specifically, the study sought to:

1. Ascertain issue of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates
2. Determine issue of over-reliance in the use of digital technologies among undergraduates

Research questions

1. What are the issues of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates?
3. What are the issues of over-reliance in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among

undergraduates?

Literature review

Educational institutions have been fighting against dishonest behavior since it became a chronic problem in academia decades ago (Schiff, 2022). As technology and the Internet have become more widely available, academic dishonesty has become more prevalent. AI-based technologies that can produce entire research papers and articles that mimic human speech make this worse and make it more challenging for teachers to spot and prevent such conduct (Sharma & Baliyan, 2020). ChatGPT and Bard are AI chatbots based on huge language models that are predicted to have a range of applications in a number of sectors. These artificial intelligence (AI) tools have been used in education for both instruction and evaluation.

Recently, a text-based artificial intelligence chatbot called Google Bard AI has emerged, which uses machine learning and natural language processing to generate responses in real time. It can be useful for completing creative projects, explaining complex topics, and generally gathering knowledge from many online sources. However, ChatGPT, a recently created artificial intelligence (AI) model that performs complex cognitive tasks, has gained popularity among academics. This feature has raised concerns about the potential for academic dishonesty among students who use ChatGPT to create essays and assignments (Murphy, 2019). It may even provide sophisticated solutions, like locating recipes that make use of the ingredients you already have in your refrigerator. According to Azab et al. (2020), it turns Google from a basic search engine into a potent virtual assistant. The user interface of the chatbot is identical to that of ChatGPT.

According to Chan and Tsi (2023), one must first comprehend what ChatGPT is and the idea of artificial intelligence in order to solve the issue of students utilizing these technologies to plagiarize work. A multidisciplinary, nuanced strategy is necessary to address the complicated, multifaceted problem of ChatGPT's ethical and responsible use in educational settings. The necessity of using artificial intelligence in education in a responsible and moral manner has been emphasized by recent research. Studies on this specific subject have concentrated on concerns like bias, privacy, and the possibility that AI will exacerbate the digital divide (Narayanan & Reddy, 2019). To make sure that ChatGPT is used in a way that is safe, fair, and respectful of students, teachers, and other stakeholders, it is crucial to adhere to responsible and ethical protocols when using the technology in educational settings.

According to Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway (2023), ChatGPT and other AI platforms create new problems with academic integrity and plagiarism. In their study, Bin-Nashwan, Sadallah, and Bouteraa (2023) raised concerns about academic honesty because of the growing use of ChatGPT by students and academics for a variety of academic tasks, including idea generation, literature summarization, and essay writing. Furthermore, the utilization of homework aids websites in helping students find answers (Emerson & Smith, 2022). According to researchers, students' need to complete research tasks pushes them to look for information online, which affects the prevalence of plagiarism (Allen, Lourenco, & Roberts, 2016). Similarly, additional research found that pressure to get a good grade, academic workload, and inadequate English language proficiency were the main reasons given by students for engaging in academic dishonesty (Costley, 2019). Assignments that have been ghostwritten and turned in as the author's own work are only one kind of plagiarism (Curtis & Vardanega, 2016). Plagiarism can take many different forms (Beute, Van, & Winberg, 2008). According to Lines (2016), professors frequently accept projects that have

been ghostwritten since they think the work was done by students.

A few research have been undertaken on the difficulties with over-reliance on AI conversation systems. Gao et al. (2022) observed a disturbing tendency where users demonstrate an over-reliance on AI conversation systems, often trusting their generated outputs, AI hallucination, without evaluation. Cognitive biases, in which judgments depart from reason, and heuristics, or the use of mental shortcuts, make this over-reliance worse and result in the unquestioning acceptance of information produced by artificial intelligence. According to Grassini (2023), algorithmic biases often arise from AI systems being trained on datasets that contain preconceptions, leading users to incorrectly perceive these biased outputs as objective. This misguided trust might further perpetuate the problem by distorting analysis and interpretation. Dempere et al. (2023) emphasized the risks associated with embedding AI dialogue systems in higher education, such as privacy violations and illegal data use. These authors warn against the normalization of intrusive data practices that might arise from an over-reliance on AI, where the collection and analysis of student data do not fully honor privacy rights. Xie et al. (2021) found that an over-reliance on unverified AI outputs can cause misclassification and misinterpretation. Frequently, this over-reliance happens without confirming the reliability and correctness of the data supplied, particularly when the material is not properly cited (Krullaars et al., 2023). Since students may rely too much on AI conversation systems for answers rather than actively engaging in the learning process, Krullaars et al. (2023) contend that an excessive dependence on these systems may reduce students' motivation and dedication to learning. Important ethical concerns have been overshadowed by the adoption and over-reliance on AI dialogue systems, with concerns about algorithmic biases, plagiarism, privacy violations, the creation of false or misleading content, and transparency issues not being sufficiently addressed (Hua et al., 2023).

There is a serious worry that relying too much on AI dialogue systems' decision-making abilities could hinder students' development of critical thinking skills due to problems like algorithmic biases, plagiarism, AI hallucinations, and lack of transparency (Carobene et al., 2023; Hosseini et al., 2023). Students may unintentionally become overly reliant on AI-generated help, which could impair their capacity to make autonomous, well-informed decisions (Buçinca et al., 2021).

Methods

The study was conducted in University of Calabar and University of Cross River State. Survey research design was adopted of the study. The population of this study comprised all final year students in the two public Universities in Cross River State. The population of final year students in University of Calabar and University of Cross River State comprised of 7,020 undergraduate students as recorded by Academic Planning Unit & Management Information System, 2023/2024 of the respective Universities. The University of Calabar has a population of 4216 final year students, being 1833 males and 2383 females. University of Cross River State has a population of 2804 final year students, 1457 males and 1347 females.

Stratified random sampling was adopted for the study. Stratification was based on institution's faculties as well as gender (male and female). On the other hand, the simple random sampling technique that goes hand-in-hand with it was used to ensure every member of the population was given equal opportunity of being selected for the study. However, 60% (9 & 6) out of 14 and 10 faculties in University of Calabar and University of Cross River State respectively was drawn.

Also, 60% (36 & 17) out of 61 and 29 departments from selected faculties was drawn.

A total sample of 409 students which constitute 10% of the population of students in the study area sampling from population of 4081 students from fifty three (53) departments of University of Calabar and University of Cross River State.

A questionnaire titled Unethical issues in the Use of Artificial intelligence Questionnaire (UIUAIQ) was developed by the researchers. This was subjected to face and content validity by three experts in measurement and evaluation in Faculty of Education University of Calabar. A trial tested on fifty (50) students from College of Health Technology Calabar to establish the reliability of the instrument. Cronbach Alpha coefficient was used to determine the reliability estimate of the instrument $\alpha = .70-.72$. The instrument was administered to the respondents and retrieved with Zero attrition rate. This process was facilitated by the researcher and two trained research assistants. The data collected was analyzed through descriptive statistics of mean and standard deviation.

Results and discussion

Research question one

What are the issues of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates? To answer this research question, responses to items 1-5 of the questionnaire were analyzed. The result of the analysis is presented in Table 1.

TABLE 1

Response on the issues of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates (N=409)

S/N	Issues of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates	Mean	SD	Remark
1	I frequently use AI-generated content (e.g., ChatGPT, paraphrasing tools) without proper citation in my academic assignments	3.2159	.66265	Significant
2	AI-generated content has made it easier for me to submit assignments without conducting independent research.	3.8655	.50490	Significant
3	I believe using AI to rewrite or generate entire academic work without crediting the source is an acceptable practice.	3.1487	.72629	Significant
4	I often rely on AI tools to complete academic tasks rather than engaging in critical thinking and problem-solving.	3.6053	.61452	Significant
5	I use AI to generate exam answers, essays, or reports without making personal modifications or verifying the accuracy of the content.	3.5381	.62233	Significant

Table 1 presents the mean ratings of issues of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates. All the isolated items recorded mean rating ranging from 3.14 to 3.86 which were above the cut-off mark of 2.50, thus, indicating that issues of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates is high. The standard deviation ranged from 0.54 to 0.72 which revealed that respondents were not too far from the mean and each other in their responses.

Research question two

What are the issues of over-reliance in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates? To answer this research question, responses to items 6-10 of the questionnaire were analyzed. The result of the analysis is presented in Table 2.

TABLE 2

Response of the issues of over-reliance in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates (N=409)

S/N	Issues of over-reliance in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates	Mean	SD	Remark
6	I depend on AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Grammarly, paraphrasing tools) for completing most of my academic tasks.	3.2407	.60913	Significant
7	I often use AI-generated content without critically analyzing or modifying it to reflect my understanding.	3.8991	.38419	Significant
8	My reliance on AI tools has reduced my ability to conduct independent research and problem-solving.	3.1770	.68196	Significant
9	I struggle with academic tasks when AI tools are not available.	3.6354	.53742	Significant
10	I prefer using AI-generated answers over reading textbooks, lecture notes, or consulting lecturers.	3.5699	.54980	Significant

Table 2 presents the mean ratings of the issues of over-reliance in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates. All the isolated items recorded mean rating ranging from 3.17 to 3.89 which were above the cut-off mark of 2.50, thus, indicating that the issues of over-reliance in the use of Artificial intelligence (AI) among undergraduates is high in the study area. The standard deviation ranged from 0.38 to 0.68 which revealed that respondents were not too far from the mean and each other in their responses.

Discussion

The findings of this study revealed that issues of plagiarism and misuse in the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) among undergraduates are highly prevalent. Furthermore, the study also established that over-reliance on AI for academic tasks among undergraduates is significantly high.

These findings align with previous studies and highlight the ethical concerns associated with AI use in higher education. The study found that many undergraduates rely on AI-generated content without proper citation or critical engagement, leading to widespread plagiarism.

This confirms earlier research by Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway (2023), who noted that AI-assisted plagiarism threatens the credibility of academic assessments. Study also supported Sadallah, and Bouteraa (2023) who raised concerns about academic honesty because of the growing use of ChatGPT by students and academics for a variety of academic tasks, including idea generation, literature summarization, and essay writing. This is consistent with the findings of Curtis & Vardanega, (2016) who reported that AI-powered writing tools have increased the ease of content generation, making it tempting for students to use them without giving due credit.

The second findings found that undergraduates exhibit a high level of dependence on AI tools, often using them as the primary source of information rather than complementing traditional learning methods. This aligns with the observations of Selwyn (2020), who highlighted the risks of AI dependency in education, particularly its potential to weaken students' cognitive abilities and independent problem-solving skills. This finding is in agreement with Gao et al. (2022), who reported that AI-based learning tools have contributed to a decline in independent problem-solving skills among students in European universities. They found that students frequently rely on AI-generated responses rather than engaging in deep learning strategies such as reading, discussions, and critical thinking (Grassini 2023).

Conclusion

The findings of this study reveal a significant prevalence of unethical issues in the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) among undergraduates in public universities in Cross River State. Specifically, the study establishes that plagiarism and misuse of AI tools are rampant among students, raising concerns about academic integrity and originality. The unchecked use of AI-generated content in assignments, research papers, and examinations undermines students' ability to develop critical thinking, problem-solving, and independent learning skills.

Furthermore, the study also indicates a high level of over-reliance on AI technologies among undergraduates, leading to reduced engagement in academic tasks and a decline in deep learning experiences. Rather than utilizing AI as a supportive tool to enhance research and knowledge acquisition, many students rely excessively on AI for completing assignments without personal intellectual input.

The consequences of these unethical practices are far-reaching. They not only compromise the integrity of university education but also diminish students' ability to compete in the global knowledge economy. If left unaddressed, this issue may contribute to a workforce that lacks critical thinking, creativity, and originality qualities essential for national and global development.

Recommendations

1. Universities should revise and enforce strict academic integrity policies that explicitly address AI-related misconduct, including AI-generated plagiarism and unethical use of AI-driven tools.
2. Higher institutions should incorporate AI ethics education into their curriculum to sensitize students about the ethical implications of AI misuse.
3. Faculty members should be encouraged to adopt AI-resistant assessment methods such as oral presentations, project-based evaluations, and critical analysis assignments.

4. Universities should establish institutional guidelines on ethical AI use, specifying how students can responsibly integrate AI tools into their learning and research. These guidelines should emphasize AI as a supportive tool rather than a substitute for critical thinking and independent learning.

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